ABOUT FOUR MILLION British soldiers served on the Western Front during World War I, manning a sector of the Allied trenches between the Channel and the River Somme. The majority of them were either volunteers or conscripts, who left their factories, offices, or fields to take up arms in their country's cause. More than 1.7 million of them were killed or wounded, yet they stuck to their task with dogged perseverance in the face of artillery bombardment, toxic gas, and machine-gun fire, and ultimately prevailed over their enemy.

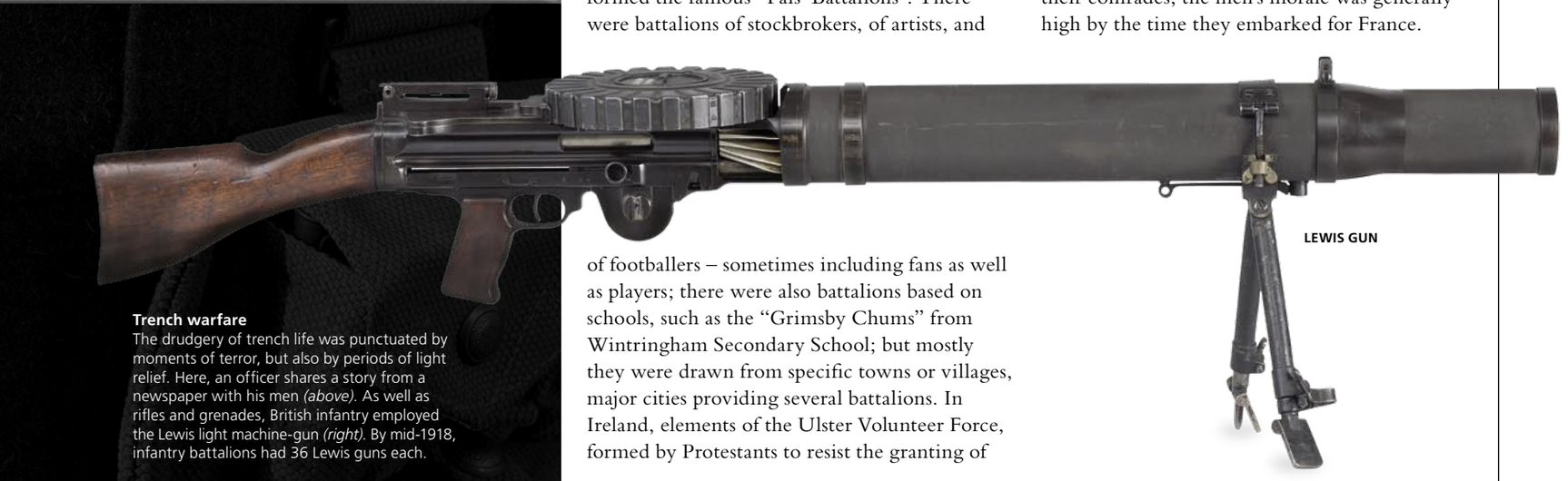
Alone among the major powers that went to war in August 1914, Britain did not have a mass conscript army. The British Expeditionary Force, sent to the Western Front at the outbreak of war, consisted of professional soldiers of the small regular army; most were wiped out in the first five months' desperate fighting. Lord Kitchener, the secretary for war, was one of the few men who from the outset anticipated a prolonged conflict. Having little faith in the territorials – prewar part-time soldiers – as a source of manpower, he set about raising a new mass army from scratch. The appeal for volunteers (with the slogan "Your Country Needs YOU") brought a flood of patriotic young men to join long queues outside recruitment centres. By the end of September 1914 about 750,000 men had come forward. Although enthusiasm began to wane in the following year, a total of 2.6 million had volunteered to fight by the time conscription was belatedly introduced in 1916.

In order to encourage men to volunteer, they were allowed to sign up on the understanding that they would serve with others from their own locality or occupational group. Thus were formed the famous "Pals' Battalions". There were battalions of stockbrokers, of artists, and of footballers – sometimes including fans as well as players; there were also battalions based on schools, such as the "Grimsby Chums" from Wintringham Secondary School; but mostly they were drawn from specific towns or villages, major cities providing several battalions. In Ireland, elements of the Ulster Volunteer Force, formed by Protestants to resist the granting of Home Rule, were permitted to enlist together, forming the 36th (Ulster) Division. Numbers of Irish Catholics also volunteered in large groups, including one of 350 rugby players and a company of Dublin dockers. The unforeseen result of the creation of Pals' Battalions was local tragedy when a formation later suffered heavy casualties – as when the "Accrington Pals" had 584 out of 720 men killed or wounded in the space of half an hour at the battle of the Somme.

TO THE FRONT

Although many early volunteers were rejected as medically unfit for service, those accepted at first far exceeded the numbers that could be trained and equipped. They were shunted off to makeshift tented camps, many kitted out with "Kitchener blue" uniforms for lack of khaki material, and, in the complete absence of weaponry, drilled with broomsticks under the orders of hidebound regular NCOs too old to be sent to the front. It was only gradually through 1915 that the men received proper uniforms and equipment, citizens began to turn into soldiers, and the New Army took shape. Toughened up by route marches and bonded with their comrades, the men's morale was generally high by the time they embarked for France.





LEWIS GUN

Trench warfare
The drudgery of trench life was punctuated by moments of terror, but also by periods of light relief. Here, an officer shares a story from a newspaper with his men *(above)*. As well as rifles and grenades, British infantry employed the Lewis light machine-gun *(right)*. By mid-1918, infantry battalions had 36 Lewis guns each.